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How to write a Cover Letter That Gets You a Job Interview

 August 2, 2024

Learn to avoid the biggest mistake job seekers make and write a cover letter that truly makes an impact.



Author:

[Robert Henderson, CPRW, Resume Expert](#)

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Most job seekers don't know how to write a cover letter. A cover letter is just a "here is my resume" opportunity!

In this article, you'll discover the secret to writing a professional cover letter that is effective. It's not hard to do and will give you a s

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Create a cover letter **over letter and do you really need one?**

A cover letter is a short document (around 300 words) that accompanies your resume. Your cover letter should not simply repeat [what your resume says](#). Instead, it should *complement* your resume, highlight your personality, and potentially address any weaknesses that could otherwise prevent you from getting an interview.

But do you really need a cover letter in 2024? The short answer is YES.

"Over 80% of hiring managers read a cover letter and 60% of applications require one as part of the application," says career coach [Madelyn Mackie](#). "Even hiring managers and recruiters who say they never read cover letters may find themselves drawn in by a particularly compelling letter."

In fact, Jobscan analyzed nearly 1 million job applications and found that including a cover letter with your resume makes you [1.9 times more likely](#) to be invited for an interview compared to those who left out a cover letter.



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"It's [Dashboard](#) [Schwartz](#). "It's about what you can do for them. Talking to them about what they care about—not about what you want—is what's going to make them want to read your letter. And to hire you!"

According to Schwartz, this is the best way to write a cover letter:

How to write a cover letter

- 1 **Paragraph 1. A single sentence (maximum two) stating the PROBLEM that the company faces. What is the issue/need/opportunity that this role will address?**
- 2 **Paragraph 2. What SOLUTION do you offer? How are you the answer to their need? Again, keep it to a sentence or two.**
- 3 **Paragraph 3. EXPLANATION: What experience do you have that supports your assertion that you can help? This paragraph can be 3-4 sentences, but keep it short.**
- 4 **Paragraph 4. CALL TO ACTION: Suggest next steps. What do you want to discuss next week?**

Since hiring managers often spend less than 20 seconds to grab their attention and get them to look at your experience matches the job, you make it easier for them

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Now that you have a clear idea of what you want to achieve in your cover letter, let's go through the process of how to write a cover letter that will make you stand out from the rest of the candidates.

1. Do your research

Before writing your cover letter, research the company to understand its current challenges and goals. Visit the company website, read their latest news and press releases, and follow their social media channels.

Don't skip this step! It's crucial for writing a cover letter that truly resonates with a potential employer and sets you apart from other candidates.

After you've researched the company, carefully read the job description. Ask yourself the following questions:

ASK YOURSELF:

- What specific problems or challenges is this role designed to address?
- How do my [skills](#) and experiences align with the job?
- Am I a good fit for the role?
- What unique value can I bring to the company?
- Are there any keywords or phrases that I should use?

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After researching the company and the role, you can [Skip](#)

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3. Prove you can do the job

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Now, you need to provide evidence that you're the right person for the job. The best way to do this is to highlight your relevant experience and achievements. Here are some things you should focus on:

- **Specific Accomplishments:** Share examples of your successes, such as increasing sales, leading projects, or improving processes.
- **Relevant Skills:** Highlight the skills that match the job requirements, like planning, organizing, technical proficiencies, or specific industry experience.
- **Problem-Solving:** Discuss times when you successfully tackled challenges, such as resolving issues, managing conflicts, or implementing solutions.
- **Industry Knowledge:** Demonstrate your understanding of the field and awareness of current trends and standards.
- **Team Collaboration:** Mention how you've effectively worked in teams, mentored others, or collaborated across departments.

Remember to keep it concise. Your letter isn't meant to tell your whole story; it's about making a compelling case that you understand the key aspects of the job.

Your goal is to leave the reader eager to learn more about you.

EXAMPLE #1

"Over the past five years, I've led digital marketing traffic by 40% and bumped up conversion rates by 25% to create compelling content that resonates with our target audience."

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that resonate with customers and drive
trend research, selecting inspiring
materials, and leading teams to transform creative concepts into market-ready products. I am proficient in Adobe Creative Suite and have experience with CLO3D, ensuring that my designs are both innovative and technically sound. My leadership skills have been honed by mentoring junior designers and managing cross-functional teams, fostering a collaborative and efficient design process."

EXAMPLE #3

"With several years of experience in CPG retail sales and merchandising, I have successfully managed sales territories, maintained product placements, and executed promotional strategies. My ability to plan and organize, combined with proficiency in Microsoft Office and familiarity with iPads, positions me well to contribute effectively to your sales team. I am adept at thinking on my feet and delivering results in dynamic environments, ensuring that products are always tagged, rotated, and optimally displayed."

4. Conclude with a call to action

When wrapping up your cover letter, it's crucial to include a final paragraph. This isn't just about expressing gratitude—it's about taking the next steps in the hiring process.

Instead of a simple "thank you," aim to propose a specific next step or a call to discuss how you can contribute to the company's goals.

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"Let's discuss how I can help NexGen Creative Agency achieve its sales goals next week.
[Dashboard](#) eting."

EXAMPLE #2

"How about we chat next week about how I can help Weissman shine even brighter? Let me know when you're free."

EXAMPLE #3

"Let's plan to discuss how my self-motivation and sales-oriented mindset can boost product visibility for Timmons Company next week. Please let me know your availability for a meeting."

There is no need to add anything more. Time is valuable, so hiring managers won't spend it on a cover letter that isn't concise and to the point.

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Expert tips for writing a cover letter

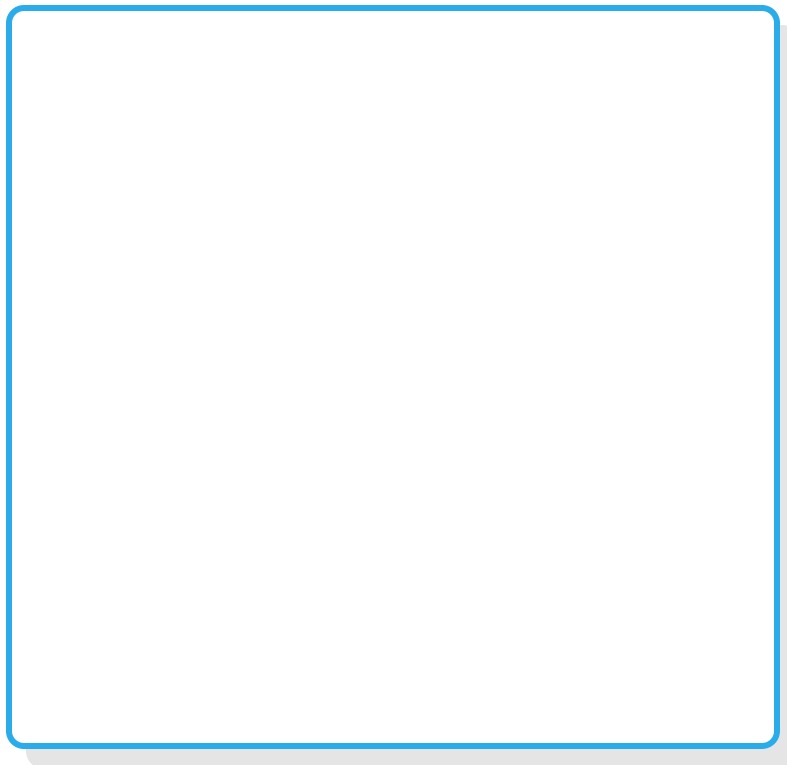
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Before diving into the content of your cover letter, it's important to format the contact details and [Dashboard](#) your name, full address, phone number, and email address.

Here's an example:



Personalize your greeting

To whom should you [address your cover letter](#) to? "For the hiring manager or recruiter for the role, and send it to [Susan Schwarz](#). "Addressing your letter to a specific person increases the likelihood of someone reading it."

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Show your personality

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While it's important to maintain a professional tone in your cover letter, don't be afraid to let your personality shine through. But remember, you don't want to overdo it—keep it concise and relevant.

Here are some ways to show your personality in your cover letter:

HOW TO SHOW YOUR PERSONALITY

- Briefly mention a specific project or experience you enjoyed.
- Highlight a distinctive skill or trait that sets you apart.
- Talk about how your values align with the company's mission or culture.
- Describe a unique volunteer experience.

Emphasize your adaptability

According to [LinkedIn](#), the top “skill of the moment” is *adaptability*. This means being open to new ideas, ready to pivot when needed, and always looking for opportunities to grow. In a world where the only constant is change, being adaptable can be a game-changer.

Here's an example of how to incorporate adaptability into your cover letter:

“In my previous role as a CPG retail sales merchant, I demonstrated my adaptability to adjust to changing market conditions, customer needs, and product offerings. This adaptability allowed me to increase sales by 15% over the course of my tenure.”

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quantified, such as increasing sales

information. Focus only on what's

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- **Do show your personality.** Share [your personality](#) on your resume and cover letter. [Dashboard](#)
- **Do be professional yet friendly.** Avoid overly formal language.
- **Do proofread your cover letter.** A single mistake can damage your chances of getting an interview.
- **Do include a call to action.** Suggest scheduling a meeting or a call.

- **Don't use clichés.** Phrases like "I am a hard worker" or "I think outside the box" are overused and add little value.
- **Don't make excuses.** Avoid explaining gaps in employment or other potential negatives.
- **Don't forget to tailor each letter.** Customizing each cover letter will help it pass through [Applicant Tracking Systems](#) (ATS).

Cover letter examples

Here are a few [cover letter examples](#) that show how to highlight your skills, show your personality, and match your experiences with the job.

Cover letter example for someone with no experience

Starting your career can be challenging, especially when you have no experience to showcase. But don't worry—a well-written cover letter can highlight your potential.

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WHY THIS COVER LETTER WORKS

- **Addresses the company's needs:** The letter I challenges the company faces, demonst

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ing of the industry and

Offering a fresh perspective and innovative ideas.

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...ention of a passion for sustainability and
...s efforts showcases the candidate's genuine
interest.

- **Proposes next steps:** The call to action is clear and professional, suggesting a meeting to discuss how the candidate can contribute, which shows initiative and confidence.

Cover letter example for someone changing careers

[Changing careers](#) can be a bold and exciting move, especially when you have a strong foundation of transferable skills. The following example of a cover letter demonstrates how to effectively highlight your previous experience and enthusiasm for a new industry.

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- **Engaging opening.** Starts with a bold question that captures attention and sets the

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...the financial services industry.

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...the experience managing a specific project that showcases the candidate's ability to improve efficiency and manage complex tasks.

- **Expresses enthusiasm:** Shows genuine excitement about the career change and the specific company.
- **Call to action:** Concludes with a clear and confident call to action, suggesting a meeting to discuss how the candidate can contribute to the company's success.

Cover letter example for someone re-entering the workforce

Re-entering the workforce after a significant break can be challenging, but it's also an opportunity to showcase your resilience and the valuable skills you've developed during your time away.

The following cover letter example demonstrates how to effectively address [employment gaps](#) while highlighting your strengths and enthusiasm for the role.

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- **Strong opening statement.** The cover letter begins with a compelling statement

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... acknowledges the employment gap upfront, which demonstrates honesty and transparency.

- **Highlights relevant experience:** The letter emphasizes past accomplishments and specific projects, showcasing the candidate's skills and ability to deliver results.
- **Shows enthusiasm for the role:** The candidate expresses excitement about re-entering the workforce and aligns their values with the company's mission.
- **Proposes next steps:** It ends with a clear call to action, suggesting a meeting to discuss how the candidate can contribute to the company's success.

Generate a perfectly crafted cover letter in seconds

If you're still having trouble writing your cover letter, try Jobscan's [AI cover letter generator](#). It analyzes both your resume and the job ad to create a completely original cover letter customized for the job you're applying for.

To learn more about how the cover letter generator works, click the button below.

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Key takeaways

Follow these key takeaways to write a compelling cover letter that attracts the attention of hiring managers and opens doors to new career opportunities.

- **Write with the employer's needs in mind.** Emphasize how your skills and experiences address the specific challenges and contribute to their goals.

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Address your letter to a specific person. If you can't find a name, "Dear Hiring

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anecdotes or unique experiences relevant to the job.

- **End with a strong call to action.** Suggest a meeting or a call to discuss how you can contribute to the company's success.
- **Proofread your letter.** A single error can torpedo your chances at getting an interview.
- **Show enthusiasm.** Showing excitement and a willingness to learn can make you a more attractive candidate.

FAQs

How long should a cover letter be?

A cover letter should be one page long, consisting of three to four paragraphs. The total word count should be around 250-400 words.

How to address a cover letter without a name

When you don't have a specific name, you can use "To Whom It May Concern," as it is considered old-fashioned.

How do you send a cover letter by email?

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First impressions are important. By showing enthusiasm for the role, you can gain an advantage over someone who doesn't send one.

What do employers look for in a cover letter?

Employers look for personalization in a cover letter, showing that it's tailored to the specific job and company. Highlight relevant experience and skills that match the job requirements. Include specific achievements that demonstrate your capabilities and contributions.

Should I give examples in a cover letter?

Yes. Providing specific examples of your achievements helps demonstrate your skills and qualifications, making your application more compelling to employers.

What does a cover letter look like?

A cover letter starts with your contact information, first and last name, the date, and the employer's details. Begin with an introduction about your suitability for the role. Include a brief section highlighting relevant experience and skills with examples. Conclude by asking for an interview.

What are the goals of a cover letter?

The primary goals of a simple cover letter are to make a good first impression, to read your resume, and offer you a job interview. Highlight your communication skills, which are highly valuable in the workplace.

What's a good opening sentence for a cover letter?

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Robert Henderson, CPRW, Resume Expert

Robert Henderson, CPRW, is a career advice writer and a resume expert at Jobscan. He is a certified professional resume writer (CPRW) and a member of the Professional Association of Résumé Writers & Career Coaches.

Robert helps produce Jobscan's articles on resume writing and optimization, cover letter writing, LinkedIn profile optimization, and job search strategies. He is an experienced copywriter, content creator, editor, and is the author of four non-fiction books.

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